

Story1

In Carl's apartment, on Linnaeusgatan, near the university, black mold is growing behind the fridge. It's the first time I've heard the term. Black mold is worse than other mold, it seems. I know about green mold, but I've always just called it mold. For asthmatics, like Carl, black mold can be plain dangerous. Carl decontaminates the fridge. He holds his breath and sprays. I'm on the toilet, door open. That's how well we know each other.

Carl shares the apartment with a friend. Martin is hard to read. Smart, a slacker with tunnel vision. He wears a thick ring, inlaid with a ruby. The ruby looks like a blood blister. He doesn't talk to me. Sometimes he grunts. I'm not sure if the sounds he makes have their own meaning, or if they are uttered out of pure necessity. Martin eats baby food out of glass jars. I hear the click when he opens a jar, a guarantee that its vacuum seal is intact. The baby food is the opposite of the black mold. Martin eats the baby food in bed and watches porn while wrapped in a blanket with a Betty Boop print. This is what he is: grunt, click, baby food, click, porn, click. With a future as a banker and a high-income individual, click. I can't imagine him being able to get hard, jerk off, come. It's as if growing or shrinking didn't exist for him.

When Martin drags himself to lectures, I borrow his porn mags, which he keeps in a rattan magazine stand that may once have held yarn or knitting patterns. A small boatneck sailor shirt for a grandchild. A beanie with a pompom on it. I think Martin harbors a lot of tenderness.

One centerfold shows a woman on all fours, with a machine gun hanging at a diagonal between her legs, against a backdrop of camouflage netting. She's wearing a military cap and feminine boots. Her lower back arches under the weight of her own willingness, and the cartridge belt burns into her skin like the lick of a whip. Or does it offer relief, like a doctor's cool fingertips searching for an inflamed tendon? Her buttocks are shiny. All of her is shiny, rubbed with oil. You can glide right into any of her orifices.

Carl has a water bed. He never changes the sheets. It doesn't matter. He smells good. When I stay with Carl I sleep in Carl's bed. Sometimes we fuck. It's nice, and it feels like the beginning or the end of a love story. Always either the beginning or the end.

Carl has a friend called Lizzy. She braids her hair and makes side buns. She wears dresses with puffed sleeves and lacing at the waist. Is this a form of irony? When I comment on the cross-stitching with a polite enthusiasm, she points out that it references a type of folklore. The dress was sewn and embroidered by a Polish Jewish aunt on her mother's side. She talks endlessly about her family. It turns out that she and Carl are related somehow. Lizzy is the chairperson of a comedic am-dram society. I can just picture her with a wine-red costume, a tall hat, drumsticks, maybe a drum, too. When she does let her hair down, it's as if she were naked, horny, drunk, limitless. It's as if she'd become the pornographic centerfold. Carl has sex with her without telling me. I find out

from Martin. So Martin does, in fact, talk to me. Just that once. He punctuates his sentence with a "moop, moop.

Lizzy is both clean and fuckable. Strict, consistent, selfish in an honest way. I'm more . . . It's twofold. I try to figure out how I'm supposed to fit into this. I often think of the word "division.

When I meet Johan, the situation changes. I fall in love with Johan, and Johan thinks he has fallen in love with me. And, when this happens, I suspect that Carl is in love with me, too. That's why I lie to Carl about Johan. Johan and I meet in secret. I want to be like Johan. When I'm alone, all I am is him. Johan says this: "The smell between the teeth, the one that comes out when you floss, is disgusting. Absolutely disgusting. And I know I'll never forget the way he says "disgusting. The word is divorced from everything that has to do with Johan's sense of humor, that has to do with us. Disgusting. It's a word that's fixed to Johan's world view. When Johan takes a trip, I borrow his clothes and practice his gestures. Thinking of myself and of existence as "disgusting helps with my longing. The disgust doesn't plug the hole, but it does decontaminate it.

I have clean, white teeth. Under Johan's bed, I find two used condoms. I don't let on about the condoms. They're something else: dry petals, a thumb brace, masking tape. Picking them up and putting them in the trash is no skin off my back. I feel the same silent satisfaction that applies to all forms of cleaning.

Carl finds out that Johan and I are together. He says that he doesn't want to see me. That I should make myself scarce. I remind him that he and I aren't together and never have been. He says that it doesn't matter what we are or have been. What's interesting is that I've been lying. I remind him that he's been lying, too. If he was in love with me and didn't say anything, wasn't that a form of lying? Carl says that what I need is a foundation course in philosophy. He says that I should ask for forgiveness, but, when I reply that first I'd need to know what I'm asking forgiveness for, he says that this is exactly the problem.

Our student union hosts a costume party. The theme is comic-book and cartoon characters. The girls are Minnie Mouse, Wonder Woman, Daisy Duck, Betty Boop. I'm the Hulk. I smear myself with green paint. Rub olive oil and dry shampoo into my hair. I tear up a pair of jeans and a plaid shirt. The only person who'd like me like this is Johan. But Johan is at a toga party across town.

Carl is dressed as the Practical Pig. Overalls, pig mask. I don't know who the Practical Pig is. He looks like a member of the Ku Klux Klan. The American South. Mangrove swamps. Banjo on the porch. Root beer. Cornbread. Violence. The heart is a lonely hunter. Carl is the opposite of all that. Except when it comes to the heart. He has a hunting license. When he sees me he delivers a slap that knocks me off my feet. He asks how dare I be here. Another Practical Pig, identically dressed but fat and maskless, comes charging. He pushes Carl and grabs me by the shoulders, gets covered in green paint. I cry

a little. Not because this hurts. But because everything hurts. He takes me to his dorm, opens a can of mussels, fries rice. Hands me shower gel, two in one. When I am nice and clean I am given food and a robe. He plays Miles Davis on the grand piano in the living room. It's morning, and the smell of cardamom drifts over from the bakery opposite. The students in the building make coffee and go to their lectures. I almost doze off on the sofa, and Practical gives me a kiss on the forehead. I embrace him. He is moist and engorged.

Johan says that he isn't in love with me. He likes me. He's interested in me. But I don't have it in me anymore. I can't be wearing Johan's clothes. They don't fit me. I can barely move. Nothing is disgusting.

I give Carl severe shortness of breath. He misses his exam. Hisses into the hospital phone that I'm killing him. I'm crying. I like Carl. He didn't beat me up. He gave me a slap. As you do in his circles. You hunt, shoot birds, decontaminate, dole out slaps. You don't lie. You withhold love. I say I'm sorry. Sorry for being cowardly and unclear. For not knowing much about integrity and honor. But I don't understand what's being said. The mix of words and actions, tenderness, violence.

I read Janson's "History of Art for my art-history class. I think of Jansson's temptation—the potato casserole served at Christmas. Traditions, patterns. Nationalism. I think of temptation itself. What it is. Of being able to give a correct description of the Venus of Willendorf. Of being on all fours with a machine gun. Of arching. Being wide open. And listening for the click.

-----The End-----

Story2

The familiar music of The Smiths drifted through the paper-thin dorm walls again as Lizzy agonized over Martin's unanswered text. Jane buried her face deeper into her philosophy essay, struggling to focus as the drama unfolded next door.

Her phone buzzed, delivering a welcome distraction. Carl.

"Want to get dinner tonight? I was thinking we could try that new ramen place." Carl always knew how to lift her mood and make her feel like the center of his world. But still, she hesitated, thinking it over for a few long seconds. She didn't want to seem too eager or available right away.

Jane thought of the countless dinners where Carl had spent the whole time focused on his phone, not even noticing she was there until the check came. She wanted to believe this time would be different, but experience told her otherwise.

"I wish I could," she replied cautiously, "but I'm swamped with work. Raincheck?"

"No problem, I understand. Let me know if you need any help studying!"

If only you actually did, she thought with another small sigh, gazing out the window at the golden sunset. Carl was good at grand romantic gestures, lavish proclamations of affection and desire, but when it came to the actual work of maintaining a relationship, she was left still waiting. Always waiting. A knock at the door startled her from her wandering thoughts. It was Martin, eyes red and swollen, clutching a crumpled letter.

"Lizzy rejected me again. I don't understand why I'm never enough." Martin always fell for women who treated him as a mere option, and here Jane was left picking up the pieces yet again. She gave him a long hug, wishing she could make him see his worth.

Martin's predilection for unavailable and disinterested women who fed his hunger for drama and emotional intensity worried her. She wanted someone generous enough to make him feel loved and secure. Someone patient, sensitive and kind. Someone who could give him the affection and intimacy he craved, who would hold him close and wipe away his tears. He needed real love, not these transient encounters and tumultuous relationships that left him shattered into pieces time after time.

Jane told Martin, kindly but firmly, that Lizzy didn't deserve him if she was unsure or unable to commit fully. His worth wasn't defined by her or any other person's assessment. Any woman would be lucky to have him, if only he chose someone available and devoted. Someone willing to make him their priority. She encouraged him to believe in himself and keep his heart open - the right person was out there.

"You deserve better Martin. Someone kind. Someone who makes you their priority and shows you your worth every single day. Someone who sees how special you are. Don't settle for less."

Martin looked up at her with a hint of longing in his eyes. Jane looked away uncomfortably. Once, in a moment of mutual loneliness and weakness, they had kissed. But she knew Martin didn't really want her - she was just his consolation prize until the next unavailable woman came along to tear his fragile heart in two. Jane contemplated the ways that she had enabled her friends to repeatedly make poor decisions in choosing romantic partners. She wished that she could protect Martin and others from the pain of broken hearts and unfulfilling relationships by making them magically realise their own worth and choose partners who would truly love and value them. Alas, she knew she couldn't force her friends into healthy relationships against their will. She could only continue to encourage them to believe in themselves, set healthy boundaries, and make good choices when it came to affairs of the heart.

"You should go get some rest," she said gently.

At midnight, Jane crawled into bed, exhausted and unsettled. Her mind drifted to Martin, probably drunk texting Lizzy again. To Carl, who would doubtless have another empty romantic gesture planned soon, with promises he had no

intention of keeping. When would her friends learn to value her for who she was, not just what she could do for them?

And Johan, unpredictable and unattainable, who drifted in and out of her life sporadically and always left her questioning everything. Her friends saw her as the dependable one, the shoulder to cry on, the rational center of their universe. Inside, though, her own world was as chaotic as theirs. While everyone else stumbled toward love, she remained stuck in place, helping guide their journeys but unable to embark on her own.

Somehow, Jane realized, she had become an accidental anchor - weighed down by the heartaches and desires of everyone around her. It was her own fault. She had made herself too available, too ready to advise and console her friends. And now here she was: stuck in an endless loop of picking up the pieces for everyone else while her own life remained at a standstill.

Jane thought about how helping those around her had shaped her identity in some ways, for better or worse. While being there for friends in times of need could be rewarding, it also meant that she had developed a habit of prioritizing others' emotional needs over her own. She felt torn between her desire for intimate connection in her own life, and the familiar role of advice-giver and problem-solver she had settled into with respect to the relationships of others.

Wanting close friends was natural and normal, but she wondered whether she needed to establish some boundaries in order to nurture her own independence and open herself up to new romantic possibilities. She knew that her friends were ultimately responsible for their own lives and decisions, just as she was for hers. Could she find a way to support them while also allowing more space for self-care, vulnerability and even a little selfishness at times?

Jane gazed out her window at the inky sky, taking a deep breath. Did she have the courage to cut herself loose? To face the seas of uncertainty, confront her fear of vulnerability, and finally start her own odyssey into the unknown?

The morning sun streamed through her curtains as Jane headed to her favorite coffee shop, needing a dose of comfort and familiarity. Her regular barista, Damien, slid a latte across the counter with a smile.

"The usual. And one of those lemon tarts you like." Damien always brightened her day with his cheerful and undemanding presence. Unlike with her friends, she felt comfortable opening up to Damien and encouraging his ambitions without fear of jealousy or judgment. "How's the garage band going?"

"It's tough, but we're making it work. How about you?"

"The usual," she said, with a wry smile. But today, things felt different. She felt different. Ready to break from routine and chase a dream of her own.

Jane spent the rest of the day feeling buoyant and brave. In her afternoon Shakespeare seminar, she found herself arguing passionately in support of one

of Desdemona's soliloquies, impressed by the character's willingness to defy social conventions in pursuit of her desires.

That evening, Johan texted to suggest meeting for a drink. To her own surprise, Jane said yes. They chose a secluded booth at the back of the campus pub. Johan ordered her favorite cider and slid into the seat across from her.

"It's good to see you," he said. His hand brushed against hers, sending a spark of electricity through her body.

"You too," she said, and meant it. Being with Johan felt reckless and alive. She gazed into his deep brown eyes, heart pounding as she finally gave voice to thoughts that had been swirling in her mind all day.

"I want more than this. More than stolen moments and maybes. I'm ready for something real."

There. She had said it. The truth she had only just admitted to herself, now out in the open. No taking it back.

Johan took her hand in his, giving it a squeeze. "So am I," he said. Jane's breath caught in her chest. "What are you saying?"

"I'm saying I'm done running. That I want you, and only you. If you'll have me."

Jane smiled, warmth flooding through her as she pulled him into a kiss. She thought of her friends, and knew she couldn't continue enabling their unhealthy relationships at the expense of her own happiness. This was her time - her chance at love, on her own terms.

"I'm saying yes," she said. And in that moment, Jane finally cast off her anchor, embarking on a journey propelled by the most powerful force of all. Jane grasped Johan's hand tightly, navigating into uncharted waters with her compass pointing due north, toward the future - and toward love.

-----The End-----

Story3

The coffee shop was buzzing with energy as the scent of freshly ground beans filled the air. Students rushed in and out, their backpacks filled with textbooks and their heads buried in laptops. Among them was Emma, a young woman with a determined look on her face. She had just started her freshman year at the prestigious university, and she was ready to take on the challenges that awaited her.

Navigating the complex social landscape of the university proved to be daunting for Emma. She found herself surrounded by classmates who seemed to have everything figured out, effortlessly gliding through student life with confidence and ease. As she watched her peers engage in lively discussions and form instant connections, she couldn't help but feel a sense of isolation.

It was during one of her morning classes that Emma first encountered Carl. He sat at the back of the lecture hall, always engrossed in his notes. His intellect and ambition were palpable, and Emma couldn't help but be drawn to him. Gradually, they started exchanging notes and discussing class assignments. Carl became her study partner, and soon, a romance began to blossom.

But as time went on, Emma realized that Carl wasn't everything she had imagined him to be. He was focused solely on his studies, rarely making time for anything else. Emma craved adventure and spontaneity, but Carl's rigid routine left no room for such indulgences. Their conversations turned into debates about grades and academic achievement, leaving little space for genuine connection.

Feeling suffocated by the relationship, Emma sought solace in her friends Lizzy and Martin. Lizzy, a free-spirited artist, was Emma's antithesis. She had an uncanny ability to find beauty in the smallest of things and encouraged Emma to explore her own creativity. Martin, on the other hand, was a dreamer. He had a charming smile and an infectious optimism that drew people towards him. Emma admired his carefree nature and his ability to live in the moment.

As Emma spent more time with Lizzy and Martin, she began to question the choices she had made. She realized that being in a relationship with Carl had stifled her own desires and aspirations. She wanted to break free from the constraints of her routine and embark on a journey of self-discovery.

One sunny afternoon, Emma decided to take matters into her own hands. She invited Lizzy, Martin, and a few other friends on a road trip. They packed their bags, hopped into a beat-up van, and set off on an adventure that would change their lives forever.

With each passing mile, Emma felt herself shedding the layers of her old self. They explored hidden gems, swam in crystal-clear lakes, and danced under starlit skies. Emma found herself laughing more, feeling alive and free. She knew that she had made the right decision.

But as the road trip came to an end, Emma found herself facing a big decision. She had developed strong feelings for Martin, and the thought of leaving behind her relationship with Carl filled her with guilt and uncertainty. She asked herself if she was being selfish for prioritizing her own happiness, or if she was finally allowing herself to grow into the person she was meant to be.

Emma's journey of self-discovery and self-reflection had led her to this moment. It was a crossroads, a pivotal moment where she had to choose between loyalty and personal growth. In the end, she realized that staying in a relationship that no longer served her would only lead to further resentment and stagnation.

Summoning the courage within, Emma ended her relationship with Carl. It was a painful and difficult conversation, but it was necessary for her own well-being. As she closed that chapter of her life, she felt a sense of relief and liberation. She was finally free to continue her journey of introspection and personal growth.

Months later, Emma found herself sitting at a café, a cup of coffee in hand, surrounded by friends who nurtured her and supported her dreams. As she looked back, she realized that her experiences with Carl, Martin, Lizzy, and Johan had shaped her into the person she had become. She was no longer defined by the complex relationships and emotional turmoil she had experienced, but rather by her strength, resilience, and unwavering commitment to her own happiness.

Emma had come full circle, a wiser and more self-assured individual. She had learned that it was okay to prioritize oneself and to let go of relationships that no longer served her. It was through the journey of self-discovery and personal growth that she had found true happiness and a renewed sense of purpose.

And as the coffee shop continued to buzz with the trappings of student life, Emma sat there, savoring the warmth of her cup and the knowledge that she had finally found her place in the complex social landscape of the university. She knew that her journey was far from over, but she was excited to embrace whatever lay ahead, confident in her ability to navigate the challenges of life with grace and resilience.

Days turned into weeks, and weeks turned into months. Emma continued to thrive in her newfound sense of freedom and purpose. She immersed herself in her studies, exploring subjects that truly ignited her passion. With Lizzy and Martin by her side, she embarked on various creative projects, pushing herself to new limits and discovering hidden talents.

As Emma dived deeper into her academic and artistic pursuits, she caught the attention of a renowned professor. He recognized her dedication and talent, and offered her the opportunity to collaborate on a groundbreaking research project. Excited and honored, Emma eagerly took on the challenge, knowing that it would be an incredible opportunity to further her knowledge and make a significant impact in her field.

The research project consumed Emma's life. She spent countless hours in the lab, pouring over data and running experiments. Her dedication and hard work were evident to all, and she soon garnered the respect and admiration of her peers and professors. Emma's confidence soared as she immersed herself in the project, pushing boundaries and making new discoveries.

But amidst her success, Emma couldn't help but feel a pang of loneliness. Her relationship with Martin had grown complicated, as their shared feelings for each other had never fully been explored. They had chosen to remain friends, but the unspoken tension hung in the air whenever they were together. Emma yearned for a deeper connection, for a love that went beyond friendship.

One day, as Emma was engrossed in her research, she received an unexpected email. It was from Carl, her ex-boyfriend. He had heard about her groundbreaking work and wanted to invite her for coffee to catch up. Emma hesitated, unsure if she was ready to face Carl again. But curiosity got the better of her,

and she agreed to meet him.

Sitting across from each other at the coffee shop, Emma and Carl exchanged pleasantries, catching up on each other's lives. As the conversation flowed, Emma realized that Carl had also undergone a significant transformation. He had finally embraced a more balanced lifestyle, one that allowed him to pursue his studies while still leaving room for adventure and spontaneity.

Carl expressed remorse for their past relationship, acknowledging how his single-minded focus had suffocated Emma's dreams and desires. He recounted the road trip they had embarked on and how it had made him realize the importance of embracing the joys of life outside academia. Carl had learned from his mistakes and was genuinely interested in reconnecting with Emma on a deeper level.

As they continued to talk, Emma felt a sense of closure and forgiveness. She realized that Carl's transformation mirrored her own journey, and that their shared experiences had shaped them into better versions of themselves. Part of her still cared for him, but she knew that their paths had diverged, leading them on separate but intertwined journeys of growth.

With a newfound sense of clarity, Emma thanked Carl for reaching out and sharing his own personal growth. She acknowledged the significance of their past relationship and the lessons it had taught her. But she also recognized that their futures were heading in different directions.

Leaving the coffee shop, Emma's heart was light. She had no regrets. The encounter with Carl had reaffirmed her belief in the power of personal growth and following one's own path. She had found her purpose, her focus, and a love for her work that consumed her in all the right ways.

As days turned into weeks and months, Emma's research continued to flourish. Her work gained recognition in academic circles, leading to invitations to present her findings at conferences around the world. She traveled to different countries, exchanged ideas with leading experts, and made connections that would shape her future career. Through it all, she remained humble and grounded, never forgetting the journey that had brought her here.

And as she stood in front of a crowded conference room, sharing her groundbreaking research with the world, Emma realized that she had come a long way since her days as a freshman. She had overcome obstacles, navigated complex relationships, and discovered who she truly was. Her journey of self-discovery had shaped her into a confident, resilient, and accomplished woman.

And so, as the applause filled the room, Emma stood tall, knowing that her story was far from over. She was excited to take on the next chapter, eager to see where her journey would lead her. With a heart full of gratitude, she was ready to embrace the challenges and triumphs that lay ahead, knowing that she had the strength and resilience to conquer them all.

-----The End-----

Story4

The second time Stella glanced at the hands of her Cartier, the minute hand had jumped fifteen minutes south. It was unlike her to indulge in past events, as her future held so much promise. But the sight of Martin in the Hunter Courtyard had upset her equilibrium, not with regret, but revulsion. Stella had always been precise about the maintenance of balance, and lately, her fortuitous participation in this delicate balance had not gone unnoticed. Martin was another envelope addressed to the past, and like the many other letters, undeserving of postage.

It wasn't long before memories came flooding back to Stella – memories of a more naïve, young woman that she had left behind. That version of her had known hardships and heartbreaks, yet was resilient beyond measure. She could feel the weight of them on her soul, like heavy coins in a rusted tin box. Yet, despite her unwavering belief in balance, Stella found herself reminiscing about the tightrope she had been traveling on during her first year at university, where the landscape bordered the unmanageable and ungovernable.

Back then, Stella knew that hope lay at the end of the line, and she had fallen off several times, but always—always—she had found a way back on. Sometimes, during quiet moments, she could still feel the bruises and the aches of where she'd landed. Time had healed those wounds, but the scars were still present, residing deep within.

Time travel, Stella thought to herself, must be reserved for memories, as only therein can humans experience both pain and pleasure without the physical strain. Painful memories were a reminder to Stella that she had grown and evolved, the college campus serving as her growth rings. The pleasurable ones were snapshots she wanted to keep close. Phantom images of faces and moments, like film negatives, came to life behind her eyes as she considered the gallery framed along the hallway of her past.

Stella dragged herself back to the first day she had come to the campus, always thankful that she had followed her instincts and taken that leap into higher education. Much of the campus, her classes, and even her roommate's habits are now merely blips in her mind – distant recollections that only surfaced from random neural paths. Yet, somehow, there was always an odd clarity when it came to Martin, as though the memory of him had been etched into her brain a little too deeply.

The first time Stella saw Martin, she didn't know whether to greet him with a handshake or to hug him. It was the beginning of a series of complex calculations that—from that point forward—imposed themselves on her life at university like a second skin. Luckily, in their first meeting, Martin had been quick to break the uncertainty and opted for a warm embrace. His enthusiasm and excitement reflected the energy that surrounded them all at the beginning of their college journey. It was contagious, but, as the inextinguishable pursuer of equilibrium,

Stella had decided to get her shots that year.

Even as Martin's figure stood fresh in her mind, Stella could hardly recall the precise details of his sturdy frame, the color of his eyes, or even the sound of his laughter. His presence had been such a constant that he'd blurred into an amorphous figure that now haunted her periphery. There were many other male figures who had come and gone, but none had tormented her as much as Martin. It was as if he was now a silhouette, ever-present but never in focus.

It must've been fate that had caused their paths to cross again on the second time she saw him. Martin hugged her again, and Stella could hardly find a reason to mind the affection. It was during the departmental reception at the beginning of the semester. She had just finished thanking Professor Simms when Martin appeared at the edge of the growing hors d'oeuvre circle.

"Hey, Stella! he cried earnestly, though he made no effort to push past the gaggle of hungry seniors. The hunger insinuated itself into Stella's memories, a concept that seemed symptomatic to her past but which she could not comprehend. The hunger she had felt earlier was somewhat satiated, but she knew it would never be entirely extinguished.

These were the markers of Martin's initial lodgment on her equilibrium scale: an earnest expression devoid of any shyness or uncertainty, and an ability to tug at her sense of self-worth with every follicle of awareness he was able to draw from her. In those moments, she had no idea that they would keep locked together in this delicate dance, cosmic entities tethered by a gravitational, inexplicable bond.

Stella had started to joke with Johan, a Norwegian PhD candidate, about Martin, who was partial to the sound of his own voice. At the departmental reception, Johan had whispered to her, "His middle name must be Hubris. Stella had misheard and stared at him, panicked. "Fiber...? she had queried, nonplussed. Johan's English, though still imperfect, revealed a growing grasp of wry humor and playful sarcasm. "No, no. Hubris. Wikipedia it!

Johan was a much-needed confidant, and their relationship was a fusion of mutual respect for each other's talents, curiosity, and shared experiences. They found solace in their conversations, laughing as they navigated the intricacies of their academic lives and the personal issues that shadowed them. As they delved into the minutiae of life, Stella discovered they shared many of the same moral values and mental frameworks. Although both had vastly different lives, they had been shaped by the same invisible, omnipotent hand.

Stella liked Johan because he was foreign and probably lonely, and more importantly, elegant. The fact that he was already entrenched in the PhD program was a source of comfort for her—his future was as impenetrable as her past seemed. Stella liked privacy, and so did Johan. They found refuge in each other's company, a cocoon of safety away from the hustle and bustle.

Stella met Lizzy in her first semester. At first, Stella found her merely pleasant, but, as Lizzy pulled her closer into her orbit with an unparalleled gravity, pleasantness was replaced by a prickling annoyance, bordering on irritation. In this way, Stella found Lizzy utterly magnetic.

Their first encounter had seemed promising. They'd met in line at the campus shop. Lizzy had been rummaging through her bag for a lost five-dollar bill, her eyes alight with irritation.

"Oh, shoot! she cried, as her eyes darted around her oversized knit headpiece. Stella imagined it had a way of obstructing her vision.

Stella had rolled her eyes, then placed her pile of coins on the counter. "Five with French dressing, the cashier droned without looking at her.

"Thank God! I don't know where I put that five. Must've left it on the kitchen table. Lizzy had turned, locking her gaze on Stella's. "What's your name?

"Stella.

"You've just saved my life! I can't study on an empty stomach, and their French dressing is everything. Seriously. Anyway, I'm Lizzy—with a Y, not an IE. We should exchange numbers and be friends. Stella could hardly disagree. She was glad for the straightness of the exchange and relieved to have been left unblemished, almost un-confronted. There were no barriers, only friendship.

Their friendship was a slow burn, with the occasional scalding, like hot wax dripping onto Stella's hand and filling in the spaces between her fingers. The nuanced dance between her and Lizzy played out throughout her college years. A symphony of great moments, surprising confessions, and letdowns wove through their days, weeks, and months together. Time—the conductor—swung his baton, and Stella rode the high notes and endured the low with a steadfast determination to find her equilibrium amid their whirlwind waltz.

The fifth time Stella saw Martin, she was starting to feel his weight on her scale. "Hey, Stella! he bellowed, stretching out her name like a pair of pants that had narrowly stopped fitting.

She fought back a sigh. "Hi, Martin.

"Have you started the assignment for Professor Simms' class?

"Uh, no, not really. Stella was irked at his persistence. There was no question he'd already submitted his.

While her memory bank was constantly refashioning itself, Stella could not deny the tug of Martin's presence in her life. She knew there would always be room for him on her mental canvas, and that the intricate threads weaving her past to her present and future would continue to bear his shadow.

Stella met Carl in the library, waving to Lizzy across the room, who was also seated by the water fountain. "Great, Lizzy cried, moving to drag a chair near Stella's table, arms akimbo. Carl had followed suit, glancing from Lizzy to Stella. As he passed across the room, his eyes did not leave Stella's, but the gaze was continually self-conscious and often shifted to his feet. Though there was a persistent discomfort, his inward look was focused.

Stella found this attractive. At five-thirty, she had descended on the library with a cold sandwich. At six, Carl had lumbered over to her and introduced himself. As they shook hands and chatted hesitantly with one another, Stella became aware of the minute-long glances cast her way from several other eager members of Lizzy's lunch circle.

This made her uncomfortable. Stella had always been cautious of the way she was perceived by her fellow students. It was at Carl's second glance that she knew she cared for him beyond his own wistful stupor. The gravitational pull between them grew stronger each passing day, turning into a bizarre, beautiful dance of love and longing.

-----The End-----